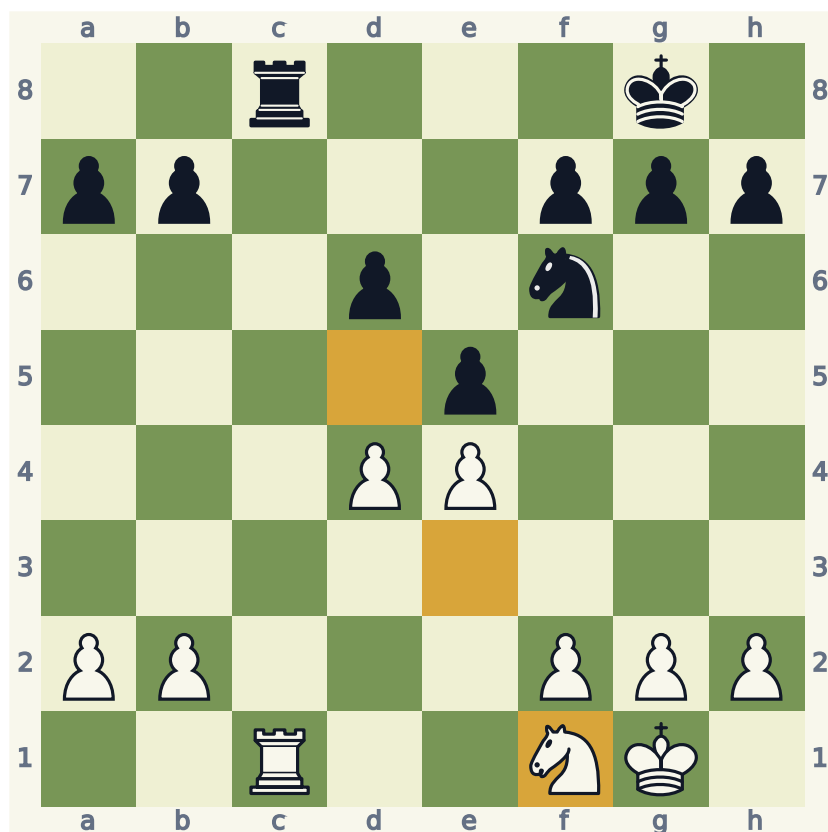


Improve your worst piece

Give every piece a destination and a job.

A piece is badly placed when it cannot contribute to the current struggle. Count useful squares and tasks, not how far it has moved. A quiet maneuver is justified when its destination improves pressure, defense or coordination faster than the opponent can create trouble.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- Nf1 has few active targets.
- d5 cannot be attacked by a black c- or e-pawn.
- Ne3 connects the knight to d5 while also covering c4 and f5.

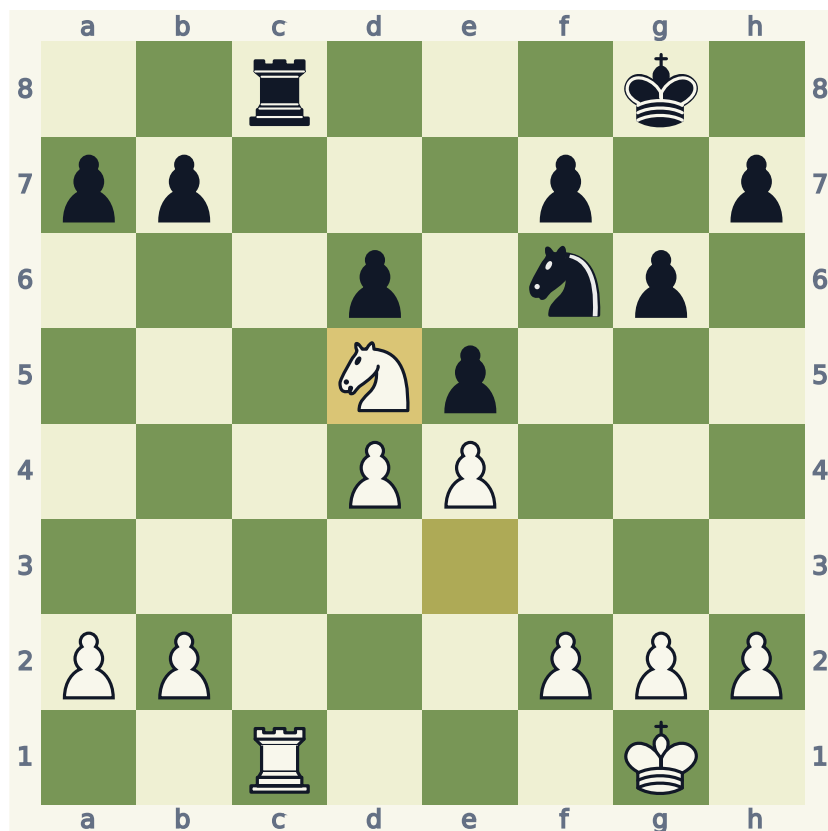
REMEMBER

- Name the piece's future task.
- Calculate the route, including exchanges.
- A useful trade can improve the whole army.

Follow the logic

1. Ne3 g6 2. Nd5

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



Ne3

Choose the destination before choosing the route. From e3 the knight can jump into d5 without moving a pawn.

...g6

This illustrative reply does not contest d5. In a real game, also consider Black's exchanges and central captures.

Nd5

The knight attacks c7, e7, c3, e3, b4, b6, f4 and f6. Its occupation is useful because it influences play, not just because d5 is central.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

Black may exchange the knight with ...Nxd5. After exd5, White must judge the resulting pawn structure and rook activity. A maneuver can provoke a favorable transformation even when the knight does not remain.

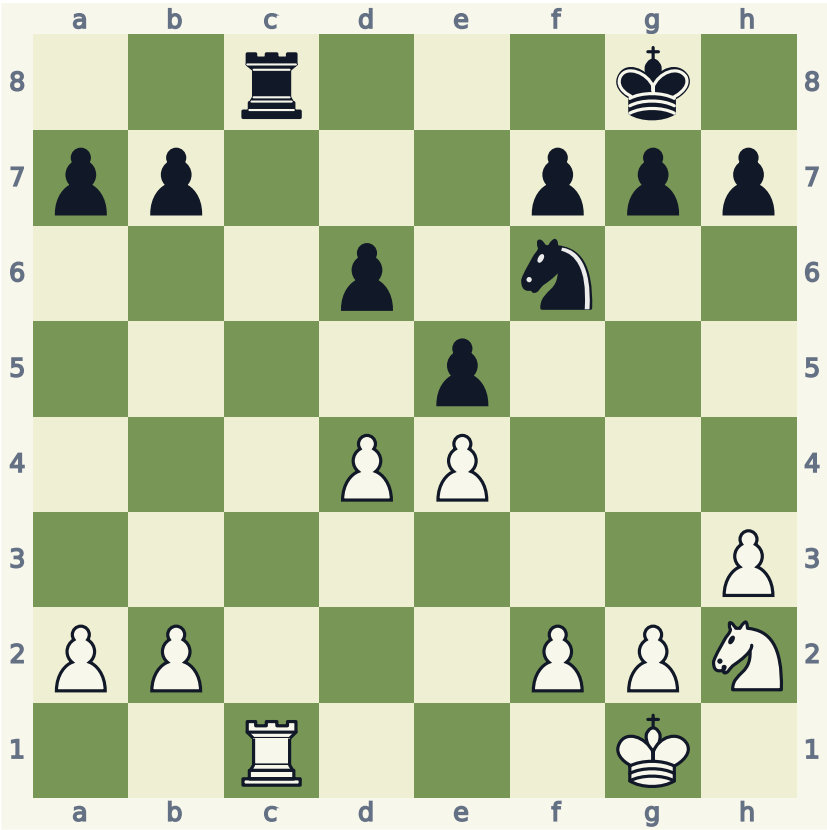
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

Do not spend several tempi improving one piece while another is hanging. A beautiful square that can be challenged by a pawn may only be a temporary stop.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Which white piece is least connected to the center?
- 2. What is the purpose of Ng4 even if Black exchanges it?
- 3. Name the structural cost of the sample exchange.

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

If Black still had a pawn on h5, how would your view of Ng4 change?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 2r3k1/pp3ppp/3p1n2/4p3/3PP3/7P/PP3PPN/2R3K1 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. Nh2 has little influence on the central battle. Rc1 already uses a file; the knight is the piece whose activity is easiest to improve. The safe route must still be checked square by square.
2. Ng4 offers to trade a passive knight for Black's active Nf6. After ...Nxg4 hxg4, the knights disappear. This illustrates improvement by exchange rather than by keeping a piece on its ideal square.
3. White receives pawns on g2 and g4, and the h-file opens. Those changes affect king safety and rook play. The exchange is a candidate to evaluate, not an automatic strategic gain.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. Ng4 Nxg4 2. hxg4

Changed feature: A black h5-pawn attacks g4. The proposed square would be unsafe unless a concrete tactic justified placing a knight there.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

Choose a quiet position. Give each of your pieces a one-word job. Spend your analysis on the piece with no useful job.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 07, 08, 10. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.